at the party describes the scene: ‘4 Rajput were celebrating their Annual Day with great gusto almost on a peacetime scale, which was difficult to understand in the prevailing situation, more so when Lieutenant Colonel Avasthy was the commanding officer. It was a gala evening to which Major General Pathania and many other officers were invited. I was also there along with Brigadier Cheema.’

The party had just begun to gather steam when a message was brought in to the GOC that two jawans had arrived at Division HQ claiming that the Chinese had overrun the Assam Rifles post at Chang-la and all their comrades had been killed. This brought the celebrations to an abrupt end as Pathania ordered Avasthy to hurriedly put together some men to verify the news. ‘Colonel Avasthy along with his Adjutant went out to address the troops which had assembled to proceed on patrolling. His troops heard him with rapt attention and his words of patriotism were inspiring. But one could notice the handicap of the troops going for patrolling. While a few were wearing jungle boots, which is the ideal, others were wearing ammunition boots which made a noise while marching.’

Meanwhile, a second patrol from PT 3446 under Jemadar Man Singh was also dispatched towards the Jalak Pu area. This group came under heavy fire and was extricated with some difficulty. Having realized that Alpha Company was dug in at PT 3446, the Chinese decided to bypass the Rajputs.

Recorded Major Nair: ‘We saw them moving down the slope to the east using hand torches, getting on to the next ridge and moving south bypassing my position in area Point 3446. This was a clear example of adhering to the principle of war—maintenance of the aim. The aim of the Chinese column that I confronted appeared to be to get to their assigned position near the road, well behind, to establish a block in order to trap the Indian troops withdrawing along the road from Se-la. When they found that they were being delayed by my troops, they left the track that I was covering, and moved away. I felt gratified that I was able to accomplish my task of denying this route to the enemy. We reached our base in the early hours of 17 November and remained there manning our defences and awaiting further instructions.’

Amidst all the wireless chatter, it was noticed that the Chinese were regularly interfering with the Indian communications. They would at times broadcast misleading messages in Hindi. One such rather simplistic